PAPERWORK SYSTEM

The Paper Pile Triage Kit

Turn the pile into five decisions.

You do not need a filing cabinet, a label maker, or a personality transplant. You need a stopping point and five places for paper to go.

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01 A five-box triage method
02 A repeatable 15-minute session
03 A next-action worksheet
04 A simple paper and digital file map
05 Help for mail avoidance and the hard envelope

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

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The pile is not a character flaw

Paper accumulates because every piece requires a decision: keep it, pay it, sign it, file it, call someone, or throw it away. When executive function is low, “I’ll deal with it later” is a completely understandable storage strategy. The problem is that later becomes a pile, and the pile becomes a source of dread.

The goal of this kit is not a Pinterest-perfect filing system. It is to reduce the number of open decisions in your home. You are allowed to have a messy drawer and a working system at the same time.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Sort before you organise**
>
> Organising asks “Where should this live?” Triage asks “What is this and what happens next?” Do the second question first. Otherwise you will alphabetise the same unresolved paper three times.

Five principles

01 **One armful at a time.** The whole pile is not a task. One armful is a task.

02 **Decide, don’t perfect.** A rough category is enough for today.

03 **Write the next action.** “Deal with insurance” is not an action. “Call the number on page 2 and ask whether the claim was received” is.

04 **Keep sensitive paper out of sight.** Do not leave account numbers, medical papers, or identity documents on the kitchen table when company comes.

05 **Stop when the timer ends.** A repeatable 15 minutes beats a heroic four-hour session that leaves you unable to face paper for a month.

The only supplies you need

- A pen.
- A timer.
- A bin bag and a recycling bag.
- Five temporary boxes, trays, folders, or labelled spots on the floor.
- This printable.
- Optional: a phone for scanning, a folder for “needs action,” and a shredder or a plan for secure disposal.

You do not need to buy a label maker before you start. A sticky note counts as a label.

If the pile is in several places

Start where you look most often. That might be the kitchen counter, the entryway, or the passenger seat of your car. Pick one. The other piles can wait their turn.

Turning over the page is the first decision. That is enough to begin.

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The five-box sort

Label five temporary spots. The names can be rough. The behaviour matters more than the label.

1. Act now

Something with a real consequence in the next few days: a bill, a form with a deadline, an appointment letter, a renewal. Put it where you will see it, not in a drawer.

2. Date it

Something that matters later: a renewal notice, a ticket, a warranty, a seasonal notice. Write the date on the page or in your calendar.

3. File it

Something you may need again but do not need to act on: paid receipts, completed policies, closed accounts, reference letters.

4. Ask / verify

You do not know what it is, whether it is real, or what you are supposed to do. Put it in one place and write the question you need answered.

5. Release it

Obvious junk, duplicate copies, expired invitations, and anything you are genuinely finished with. Recycle the paper; shred what contains sensitive information.

The two-second question

For each item, ask only: **What is the next physical action?**

- If the answer is “put it in the action folder,” do that.
- If the answer is “write a date in my calendar,” do that.
- If the answer is “I don’t know,” put it in Ask / verify.
- If the answer is “nothing,” release it.

You do not have to complete the action during triage. Sorting is a separate job from doing. Trying to do both at once is how a 15-minute sort becomes a three-hour research project.

WATCH OUT

Protect sensitive documents

Do not write full account numbers, government ID numbers, passwords, or medical details on this printable. If a document contains those things, move it to a secure place and record only the action you need to take.

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What counts as done

A triage session is done when the timer rings, not when the pile disappears. If five papers have homes and three actions are written down, the session worked. Take the win before your brain decides it was not enough.

My five spots

BOX	WHERE IT WILL LIVE THIS WEEK	WHAT BELONGS HERE
Act now		
Date it		
File it		
Ask / verify		
Release		

A done-enough checklist

- [ ] Every Act now item is visible.
- [ ] Every Date it item has a date attached.
- [ ] Every Ask / verify item has a question written next to it.
- [ ] The Release bag has left the room.
- [ ] I wrote down one next action.
- [ ] I stopped when the timer said stop.

My rule for the next session

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The 15-minute triage session

Use this page as your launch checklist. The session has three parts: set up, sort, and close. The close is what makes it repeatable.

Set up · 3 minutes

- ☐ Clear a table or a patch of floor.
- ☐ Put the bin, recycling, and five boxes within reach.
- ☐ Put your phone on silent, or use it only for the timer.
- ☐ Fill a glass of water.
- ☐ Decide one stopping point: one armful, one counter, or one drawer.
- ☐ Set the timer for 15 minutes.

Sort · 10 minutes

- ☐ Pick up one piece of paper.
- ☐ Ask: what is the next physical action?
- ☐ Put it in one of the five boxes.
- ☐ Do not open a new browser tab unless the paper cannot be understood without it.
- ☐ Do not start the action unless it takes under two minutes.
- ☐ Keep moving. Pauses to read every word are how the pile wins.
- ☐ When you find something emotional, put it in Ask / verify and keep sorting.

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Close · 2 minutes

- [ ] Put the File it box in its temporary home.
- [ ] Put the Act now papers where you will see them.
- [ ] Write the two or three actions you noticed in the action list on the next page.
- [ ] Move the Ask / verify pile to one folder or envelope.
- [ ] Put the Release bag by the door or in the bin.
- [ ] Write one sentence: what did this session actually clear?

My session close-out

Where the boxes go next

BOX	ITS NEXT HOME	WHEN IT MOVES
Act now		
Date it		
File it		
Ask / verify		
Release		

TRY THIS

Take a photo before you put it away

If you are worried you will forget what was in the pile, photograph the Act now and Ask / verify papers. The photo is a backup, not a second pile. Delete it once the action is handled.

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The next-action list

A paper pile usually hides a short list of actions. Use one line per action. Keep the description physical and small enough that a tired version of you could start it.

Actions found

ACTION (START WITH A VERB)	FOR WHICH PAPER?	DEADLINE OR CHECK DATE	DONE
Call and ask whether the claim was received	Insurance letter, page 2		☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

If the action takes under two minutes

Do it now, while the paper is in your hand. Put the paper in Release or File it afterward. If it takes longer, write it down and move on. The two-minute rule is not a life philosophy; it is a way to stop small tasks from becoming invisible.

The follow-up date

Some actions wait on another person. Write the date you will check back. “Wait” is not a complete plan.

WAITING ON	CHECK BACK ON	WHAT I WILL DO IF THERE IS NO REPLY

The stop line

You do not need to complete every action today. Choose one. Put a dot beside it. That dot is your next contact with the paperwork, not another failure to finish it.

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A file map you can actually use

A filing system works when you can find something without remembering where you put it. Broad categories are easier to maintain than a perfect taxonomy. Start with six folders or six hanging files. Add detail only if you keep missing things.

The six starting folders

FOLDER	PUT THIS HERE	KEEP IN MIND
Home	Lease or deed, utilities, home insurance, repairs, warranties	Keep current insurance and lease or deed in a secure place.
Money	Bills, bank letters, tax documents, receipts you need	Do not write account numbers on the folder label.
Health	Visit summaries, test results, insurance notices, receipts	Store privately. Share only with people who help with your care.
Identity	Passport, birth certificate, Social Security or local ID papers, immigration documents	Use a locked or fire-resistant place. Check official replacement rules before mailing anything.
Work	Contracts, pay records, training certificates, retirement paperwork	Keep confidential work material separate from household paper.
Life misc.	Pets, school, travel, memberships, instructions, warranties	This is allowed to be a catch-all. A real system needs one.

My folder plan

FOLDER	WHERE IT WILL LIVE PHYSICALLY	WHERE IT WILL LIVE DIGITALLY
Home		
Money		
Health		
Identity		
Work		
Life misc.		

TRY THIS

Label the place, not just the folder

“Blue file box, top shelf” is easier to remember than “the filing cabinet.” Write the location somewhere you will see it when the folder is not in your hands.

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Physical or digital?

You do not need to scan everything. Scanning a whole archive can become another unfinished project. Choose by use:

- **Keep paper:** documents you are required to keep in original form, identity documents, and things you need to hand to another person.
- **Scan and file:** receipts you may need for reimbursement, instructions, warranties, and papers you want to reference but rarely need in original form.
- **Release:** duplicates, expired notices, and completed items that carry no continuing obligation.

A folder name that helps

“Important” is not a useful folder name, because everything feels important when you are overwhelmed. Use the situation instead: “Home – current lease,” “Money – taxes 2026,” “Health – visits and results,” “Work – current contract.”

My folder map

FOLDER OR BOX	PHYSICAL HOME	DIGITAL HOME	WHAT GOES IN

GOOD TO KNOW

Retention rules are local and specific

How long to keep tax, medical, employment, or property records depends on where you live and what the record is for. This page is a starting point, not legal or tax advice. Check an official source or a qualified professional before shredding documents with long-term consequences.

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Decode the envelope

The unknown is heavier than the task. Most mail becomes easier once you name what it is and what kind of response it needs. This table is a starting point, not instructions for your exact situation.

WHAT ARRIVED	WHAT IT USUALLY IS	A SENSIBLE FIRST MOVE
Bill or statement	A request for payment or a record of activity	Note the due date and the minimum action. Check it against what you expected before paying.
Insurance explanation of benefits	A statement of what was billed and paid — not always a bill	Check whether it says you owe something. If confused, call the number on the document.
Renewal notice	A reminder to renew or update something	Write the renewal date and the steps. Do not assume the price is unchanged.
Government form	A request for information or a notice of a decision	Read the deadline and the official contact channel. Verify the sender before sharing personal information.
Employment or benefits letter	A change, decision, or request for action	Note the date and who to contact. Keep a copy.
Legal or court notice	A document with legal consequences	Do not ignore it. Check the issuing office or seek qualified legal help. This kit cannot tell you what it legally means.
Collection notice	A claim that money is owed	Verify the sender and the debt before paying. Check official consumer resources or legal help if unsure.
Warranty or receipt	Proof of purchase or coverage	File it with the item's name and date. You rarely need to act immediately.
Invitation or event notice	A date and RSVP request	Decide now: yes, no, or ask. Then release the paper.
Anything that feels off	Could be legitimate, could be a scam	Do not use the contact details printed only on the letter. Look up the organisation independently.

When you do not know what it is

Use the Ask / verify box. Write three things on a sticky note and attach it:

01 What I think this is.

02 What I need to know.

03 Who or where can tell me the answer.

That turns a mysterious document into a small research task. It also stops it from floating back into the pile without a next step.

A phrase that saves time

"I received a notice and I'm not sure whether it requires action. Can you tell me what it is and what the deadline is?" This is a complete, respectful question. You do not need to apologise for not understanding the paperwork.

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Keep, scan, or shred

Paper decisions carry privacy and legal consequences. When in doubt, slow down. The safe answer is usually to keep the original until you verify the rule.

Before you shred

- ☐ Is it definitely a duplicate or a completed item with no ongoing obligation?
- ☐ Could it be needed for taxes, insurance, employment, immigration, a warranty, or a legal matter?
- ☐ Is it the only copy?
- ☐ Have I checked an official retention rule if I am unsure?
- ☐ Does it contain an account number, ID number, signature, or medical detail?

If you are unsure about any answer, put it in Ask / verify instead of shredding.

Sensitive paper

Identity documents, financial statements, medical records, and anything with an account number deserve more than the recycling bin. Use a shredder if you have one. If you do not, store the paper in a secure “to shred” bag and deal with it when you can, rather than leaving it visible in the bin.

Do not burn paper indoors or in unsafe conditions. Do not put sensitive documents in a shared recycling bin if secure disposal matters in your household.

Scanning without turning it into a project

01 Choose one small stack.
02 Scan or photograph with a scanning app.
03 Rename the file with a date and a plain description.
04 Put it in the right digital folder.
05 Mark the paper for secure disposal or file the original if it must be kept.
06 Stop at the end of the stack.

A useful file name: `2026-03-14 home insurance renewal.pdf`. A file name like `Scan_00473.pdf` is technically a file, but not a system.

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Digital safety basics

- Keep sensitive scans in a secure folder or encrypted storage if available.
- Do not send identity documents through ordinary chat or paste them into a consumer AI tool.
- Keep a backup of important digital files in a second place.
- Do not put passwords in the same folder as the documents they protect.

My secure-document plan

Where identity documents live:

Where sensitive paper waits for shredding:

Who else knows where the important documents are:

My digital checkup

- ☐ I know where identity documents live.
- ☐ Sensitive scans are in a secure folder.
- ☐ Important files have a second backup.
- ☐ Passwords are not stored beside the documents they protect.
- ☐ I know which account I will secure next.

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When the envelope is the hard part

Sometimes the task is not sorting. It is opening. A letter can carry a bill, a diagnosis, a rejection, a demand, or a reminder of something you have been avoiding. Avoiding it is a nervous-system response, not a personality defect.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Open one. Do not solve one.**
>
> You are allowed to open an envelope without handling the contents. The goal of this first step is information, not resolution.

The lowest-barrier opening routine

- ☐ Sit somewhere comfortable with a bin and a pen.
- ☐ Put on a timer for five minutes.
- ☐ Open one envelope.
- ☐ Turn the letter face up and read only the first paragraph.
- ☐ Circle the sender and any date.
- ☐ Put it in Act now, Date it, or Ask / verify.
- ☐ Write one next action, or write “need help to understand this.”
- ☐ Stop.

If opening is still too much, ask someone you trust to sit with you while you do it. They do not have to read the letter. Their job is presence, not fixing.

If the paper is about money

Shame makes bills heavier. Try to separate the facts from the story:

- Fact: “There is a balance due on the 14th.”
- Story: “I am bad with money and everyone knows it.”

Only the fact is useful for planning. If the amount is unmanageable, contact the organisation and ask about options before the deadline. A brief phone call or message can be more effective than another week of avoidance. For legal, tax, or benefits advice, use a qualified professional or official service.

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If the paper is about health or care

You do not have to interpret it alone. Write down the question and call the clinic, insurer, or person who sent it. If you are supporting someone else, ask them what they want to know before you start reading.

My hard envelope plan

The envelope I have been avoiding:

The smallest opening step:

Who I can ask to sit with me:

The date I will try:

If the paper is about someone else

Ask what they want to know before you start reading. You are helping with the paperwork, not taking over the decision. Share only what they need and keep the original documents where they can find them.

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The quarterly 15-minute reset

The point of a system is not to prevent paper from ever building up. It is to make the return trip short. Once every season, spend fifteen minutes checking the places where paper goes to hide.

The quarterly checklist

- ☐ Clear the “Act now” papers that are already complete.
- ☐ Check the “Date it” box for dates that have passed.
- ☐ Move receipts and completed documents into File it.
- ☐ Look at the Ask / verify folder. Choose one question to resolve.
- ☐ Shred or securely dispose of the release paper.
- ☐ Check that identity and sensitive documents are in their secure place.
- ☐ Update the household command center if contact details or routines changed.
- ☐ Choose one thing to make easier next quarter.

The one-file fix

If the system has collapsed, do not rebuild the whole filing cabinet. Make one “current admin” folder with five subdivisions: Act, Date, File, Ask, and Release. Keep it next to the place where mail lands. When it fills up, do another triage session. A system that can be restarted is more useful than one that has to stay perfect.

My next audit date

What worked and what did not

I WANT TO KEEP DOING	I WANT TO STOP DOING	I WANT TO TRY ONCE

> TRY THIS
>
> **The pile is allowed to be smaller than the problem**
>
> A 15-minute session may not resolve the paperwork. It can still lower the noise, surface the urgent item, and give you a place to start next time. That is a real outcome.

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Paper is a tool, not a report card

You will not be graded on the filing cabinet. The useful question is not “Is everything organised?” It is “Can I find the thing I need when it matters?” A messy system that lets you find the insurance letter is better than a beautiful system you are afraid to touch.

The one-page takeaway

- Sort by next action before you try to organise.
- Use one armful and one timer.
- Put sensitive documents in a secure place.
- Keep the categories broad enough to maintain.
- Open one envelope before trying to solve one envelope.
- When unsure, verify before shredding.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not owe anyone a perfect filing system. You owe future-you a fighting chance of finding the letter.

ONE LAST THING · 08

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Set a 15-minute timer and sort one armful of paper into the five boxes. Do not aim to finish the pile; aim to make one decision at a time.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 09 Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan
- 12 The Household Command Center

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